AEP FROM ZERO • PART 1 • KNOW YOUR CUSTOMER (AEP)

EPISODE 07

AEP Identity Stitching and the Identity Graph

How does identity stitching work in Adobe Experience Platform? In this AEP identity graph tutorial, Bloom's analyst asks how many customers the brand really has, and the team traces one customer's five fragments, from an anonymous ECID on her phone to her email and BloomID, into one person. You will learn the deterministic rule behind identity resolution, why the linking event (a sign-in) turns anonymous traffic into a known customer, and how to model ECID to email stitching in AEP Graph

Previously: the data is in. Who is who?

- Last time: 497 orders landed safely
- Rohan asks: how many customers do we have?
- CRM, orders and website all disagree
- Today: five fragments become one person
- Plus: the decoys and the family tablet

KEY IDEA

Bloom's data finally landed, but nobody can say how many customers it holds. Today: how AEP decides that two records are one person.

One customer, counted three times

Phone app: browsing, ECID only

▼

7:44 PM: Vitamin C Serum into cart

▼

She signs in on the app

▼

7:52 PM: she buys on her laptop

▼

Bloom sees three different people

KEY IDEA

On 18 August Priya browsed anonymously on her phone, signed in on the app and bought on her laptop. To Bloom's systems, that looked like three people.

Passport, driving licence and gym card

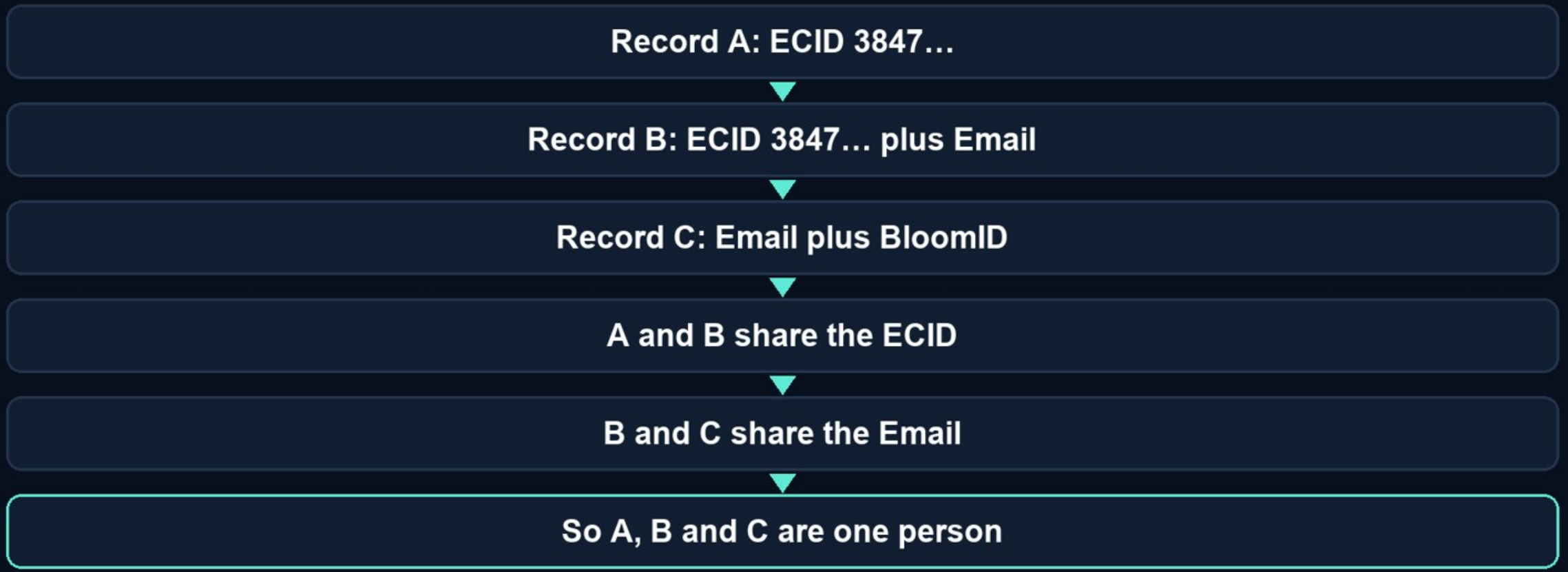
Namespace	What it identifies at Bloom
Email (standard)	The person; Bloom's primary identity
BloomID (custom)	Bloom's own customer number
ECID (standard)	A browser or app install, not a person

Passport, driving licence, gym card: three numbers, one person

KEY IDEA

An identity is a pair: a namespace, meaning the kind of ID, and a value. Three different numbers can all point to one person.

How identity stitching works



KEY IDEA

Records that share an identity value are treated as the same person, directly or through a chain. That simple rule is identity stitching.

Priya's five fragments on the table

#	Record	Identities it carries
F1	Product view, phone app	ECID 3847…
F2	Add to cart, 7:44 PM	ECID 3847…
F3	App sign-in	ECID 3847… and Email
F4	Order BLM-88412, 7:52 PM	Email and BloomID
F5	CRM loyalty record	Email only

KEY IDEA

Kavya laid out Priya's five records, four from that evening and her CRM record. Each carries different identities; none carries all three.

What is an identity graph?

- Dots, or nodes: identity values
- Lines, or edges: records that carry two values
- Priya: ECID, Email and BloomID in one graph
- One connected graph means one person
- One missing line: two graphs, two people

KEY IDEA

An identity graph is the web of links between identity values. Values are the dots; records that carry two values together draw the lines.

The linking event: the hero of the story

Before the sign-in	After the sign-in
Browsing is anonymous	The ECID is bound to Priya
Retargeting is blind	Earlier browsing attaches to her
No personalisation	Personalisation is possible

KEY IDEA

A linking event is one record carrying an anonymous ID and a known ID together, usually a sign-in. It binds the device to the person.

Pull out the sign-in

F1, F2: ECID 3847… only

▼

F3 removed: no ECID plus Email record

▼

The graph splits in two

▼

Phone events: a device, no owner

▼

Order and CRM: Priya, no browsing

KEY IDEA

Remove the linking event and the graph snaps in half. The phone events float away as an anonymous device with no owner.

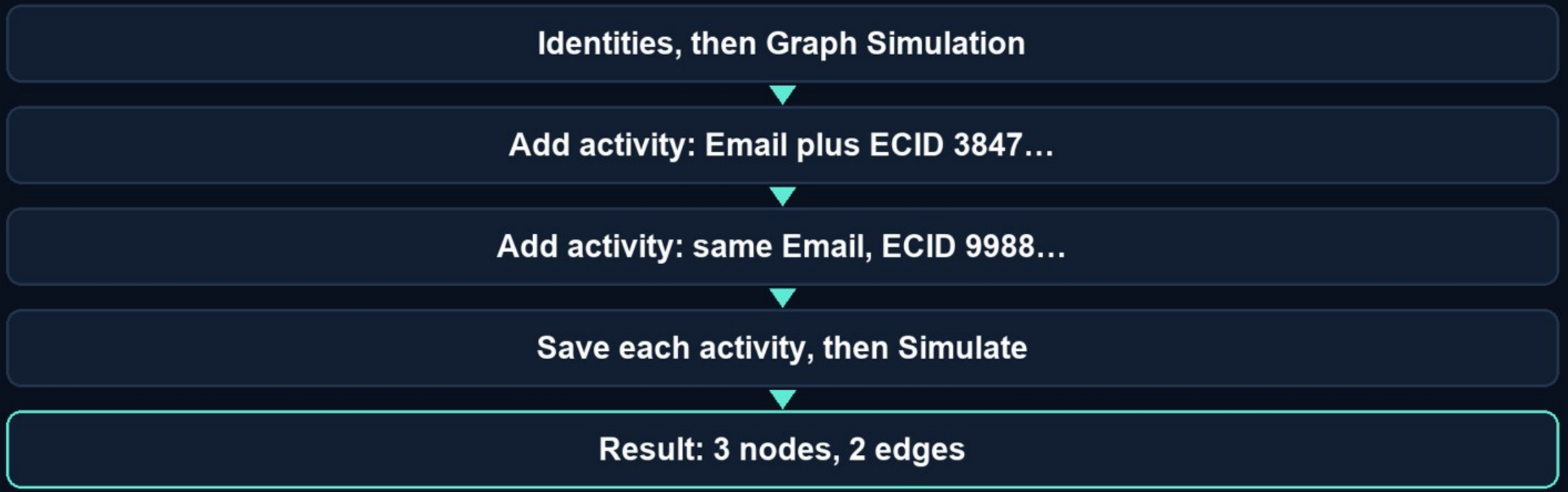
The decoys that must never join

Record	Identity	Shares with Priya?
Web event, product view	ECID 9021…	Nothing: stays out
Arjun Patel's order	His own email	Nothing: stays out
F3, Priya's sign-in	ECID 3847… and Email	Both: it joins

KEY IDEA

Recognising who does not belong is half the skill. A different ECID and Arjun Patel's order share nothing with Priya, so they stay out.

Graph Simulation: stitching with no data



KEY IDEA

Graph Simulation, a tab under Identities, draws the graph from activities you type in. It needs no ingested data, and it ingests nothing.

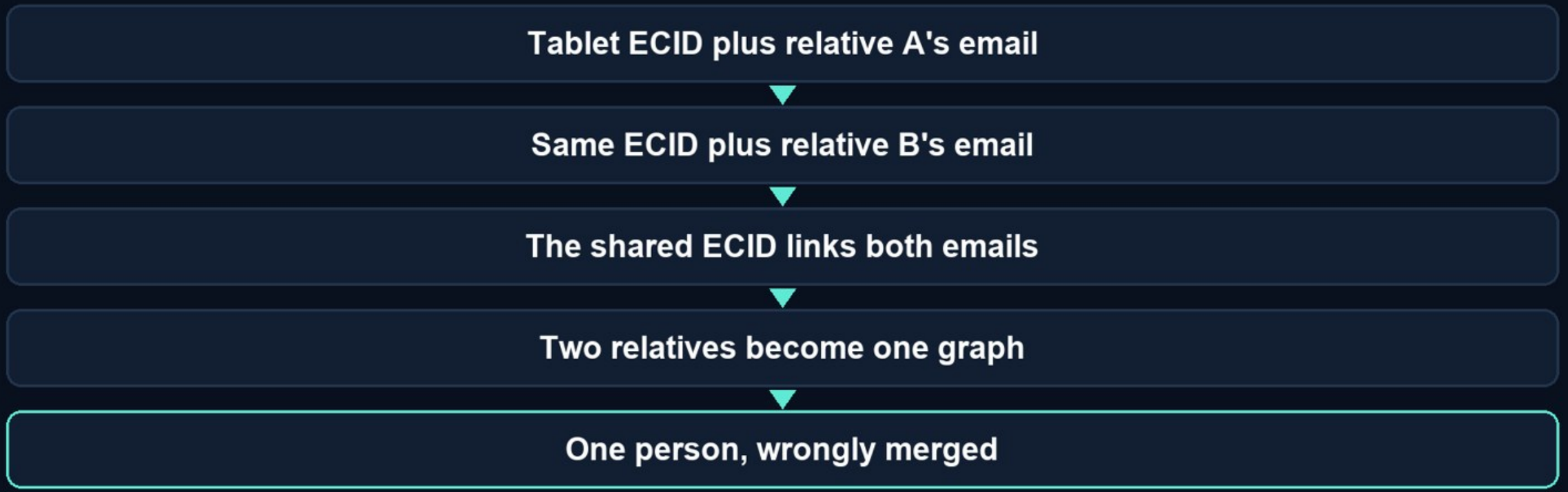
Graph Simulation's limits and traps

- Only the 16 standard namespaces
- Custom BloomID is not selectable
- Each activity needs 2 or more identities
- The dropdown can overwrite another row
- Disconnected nodes: the emails differ
- Ingests nothing: a safe place to practise

KEY IDEA

Only the 16 standard namespaces appear, so BloomID cannot be simulated. Check every row, because the dropdown can overwrite the wrong one.

The family tablet that merged two people



KEY IDEA

One family tablet's ECID appeared with two relatives' emails. Because links chain, the platform would treat two people as one. That is over-linking.

Guardrails: where stitching goes wrong

Risk	Guard
Shared family devices	Watch login patterns; limit device links
Runaway test or support logins	Find them and keep them out
ECID-only profiles	Treat as anonymous until stitched
Weak primary identity	Use email, not a device

KEY IDEA

Watch shared devices, exclude runaway test and support logins, treat ECID-only profiles as anonymous, and keep a strong primary identity: email.

Interview corner

- “Identity stitching turns anonymous traffic into
- known customers at the moment they authenticate.”
- Proof: Priya's sign-in, F3, closes her graph
- Push-back: links chain, no direct overlap needed
- Risk side: the family tablet and its guard

KEY IDEA

Say it in one sentence: identity stitching turns anonymous traffic into known customers at the moment they authenticate.

Recap, your question, and next time

- Share a value, same person; links chain
- The linking event closes the graph
- Over-links: shared devices, test logins
- Rohan's honest count comes in Act Three
- Next: Dallas or Austin? Merge policies

KEY IDEA

Shared values link records, the sign-in closes the graph, and shared devices over-link. Next: when Priya's records disagree, which value wins?